E.C.H.O: An Intent Aware Personal Memory System for Unified Search Across Email, Web, and Video History

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***Abstract*—In a single day, a person meets information in many places: the inbox, the browser, and video sites. Each place keeps its own history behind its own search box, so finding something again starts with guessing where it was seen. We present E.C.H.O (Efficient Contextualized History Orchestrator), a personal memory for a single user. It collects Gmail, Chrome, and YouTube activity into one store on the user's own laptop and answers questions about it in plain language. All mail is kept, except what Gmail itself files as spam or trash. A web page or a video, though, is kept only when signals such as foreground time, scrolling, watch time, or a return visit show that the person actually attended to it. In the background, a worker then cleans each item and pulls text out of its attachments. It also assigns one of five broad categories and embeds the item for search by meaning. A question goes to a language model that may call a single search tool, which is plain code. This tool runs keyword and vector search together and fuses the two ranked lists by reciprocal rank fusion. It widens the search when the results look weak, and it reorders the survivors with a local cross encoder. A typical question costs two model calls, and the code allows at most six. Storage, indexing, and search all run locally. The model receives the question and bounded excerpts of the top results, but never database rows or the whole store. Also, a wellbeing module describes how time is spent without judging it. It sorts items into personal goals, adding only confident items on its own and leaving the rest for the user's approval. On a test collection of 119 items and 38 questions, the first ten results held 93% of the relevant items, a question needed 2.3 model calls and a median of 8.1 seconds, and the capture rules agreed with their specification in all 13 clean scripted sessions. The tests also show that semantic search alone ranked the results better than the full pipeline on this small collection, and we discuss why.**

***Index Terms*—personal information management, retrieval augmented generation, hybrid search, reciprocal rank fusion, tool calling agents, intent aware capture, local first software, digital wellbeing**

I. Introduction

Suppose a student is preparing for a job interview. The company sends an email, and over the following days the student reads articles about operating systems in Chrome and watches a few tutorials on YouTube. A week later, the student wants that material back. Now the email sits in Gmail and the videos sit in the YouTube watch list, while the articles are buried in the browser history. Each of these apps has its own search box, and none of them knows about the other two. So the student either searches all three, one at a time, or starts again from scratch.

The idea of a machine that remembers what its owner has seen is not new. Bush called it the memex in 1945 [1], and later systems such as Stuff I've Seen [2] and MyLifeBits [3] built personal stores of mail, pages, and documents. But two problems still stand in the way of daily use. The first problem is noise. A browser logs every page that opens, including stray clicks and tabs closed after two seconds. So a memory built directly on that log fills up with things nobody read. The second problem is recall by exact words. A search box needs the right keyword, while people remember loosely, as in "the OS material I read after the interview email."

E.C.H.O tackles both problems. It watches Gmail, Chrome, and YouTube, but it keeps a page or a video only when engagement shows real attention. All items share one data model on the user's laptop, where they are enriched in the background and can be queried in natural language. Every answer is grounded in the stored items, following retrieval augmented generation [4].

The main contributions are:

- An intent aware capture layer with a separate rule set for each source, along with privacy filters that act before anything is stored. Here, sensitive pages lose their text and secret parameters are cut from addresses, and private work apps contribute only a page title.
- A local storage model in which emails, pages, and videos share one central table. PostgreSQL is the permanent record, Redis holds short lived state, and the FAISS index can be rebuilt from PostgreSQL. Attachment text is already extracted when the mail arrives, so it is searchable as well.
- A bounded agentic retrieval loop. The language model plans and phrases the searches, while a deterministic tool does the actual searching. This tool runs hybrid keyword and vector search, rank fusion, a rule based quality check with widening, and cross encoder reranking. A typical question needs two model calls, and the code sets a hard limit of six.
- A wellbeing module that reports time, sessions, and self declared regret only in descriptive terms. Along with it comes a grouping engine for personal goals. It files an item on its own only when two signals agree, and the user can undo that in one click. Every other item waits for the user's explicit approval.

Section II reviews related work, and Section III gives an overview of the system. Next, Section IV covers capture, storage, enrichment, and retrieval, and Section V describes the wellbeing module and user groups. Section VI then covers privacy, and Section VII covers the implementation. The evaluation is in Section VIII. Finally, Section IX lists the limitations and Section X concludes.

II. Related Work

A. Personal Information Management

Bush imagined the memex as a desk that holds a person's books, records, and letters and brings any of them back quickly [1]. Stuff I've Seen built one index over everything a person had already seen, whether an email, a web page, or a document, and used that prior exposure as a cue for search [2]. MyLifeBits kept personal data in a SQL database, with the aim of storing everything that could be captured [3]. E.C.H.O shares the same goal of refinding, but it differs in two ways. First, it filters at capture time and does not store everything. Second, it goes a step beyond a query box and answers questions in natural language.

B. Retrieval Augmented Generation and Tool Use

Retrieval augmented generation couples a retriever with a text generator so that the generated answer draws on the retrieved documents [4]. E.C.H.O applies this idea to a personal collection and arranges the steps as a graph built with LangGraph [5]. ReAct showed that a language model can interleave reasoning with actions such as search calls, and that grounding each step in tool output reduces invented facts [6]. We borrow this pattern, but in a deliberately narrow form. The model has exactly one read only tool, and apart from two small local encoders, that tool contains no model of its own. Also, the number of rounds is capped in the code.

C. Hybrid Search and Reranking

Sentence embeddings such as Sentence BERT make it possible to compare texts by meaning, using cosine similarity [7]. E.C.H.O embeds every item with a small local sentence model [8] and searches the vectors with FAISS [9]. For keyword search, it uses the full text search built into PostgreSQL. The problem is that the two methods score on unrelated scales, so directly adding their scores is not meaningful. Reciprocal rank fusion solves this, as it uses only the position of each item in each list [10]. After fusion, a cross encoder reads the question and a candidate together and scores how well they match. Nogueira and Cho showed that this works well for passage reranking [11]. Our cross encoder is a compact MiniLM [12] model trained on the MS MARCO passage ranking data [13].

D. Local First Software

Kleppmann et al. describe local first software, in which users keep ownership of their data and the application works from a copy on their own device [14]. E.C.H.O follows the same idea, as the database, the vector index, the cache, and both encoders run on the user's laptop. The hosted language model receives only bounded pieces of text.

E. Digital Wellbeing Tools

Lyngs et al. reviewed hundreds of digital self control apps and browser extensions and found that most of them block, limit, or track usage against a goal [15]. E.C.H.O is different from these tools. It shows where the time went and lets the user mark the items they regret, but it does not score the user or block any content. It also does not label time as wasted.

III. System Overview

Fig. 1 shows the main parts of the system. First, data comes in through three connectors. The Gmail connector reads mail through the Gmail API with OAuth and asks only for the changes since its last check. A Chrome extension observes desktop browsing and YouTube playback, and the YouTube connector then fills in the video details from the YouTube Data API. Every connector hands its items to one FastAPI gateway, where the storage engine writes each item in a single transaction and skips duplicates.

Next, there are three stores, and each has a separate job. PostgreSQL is the permanent record of every item. FAISS holds the embedding vectors, and it can be rebuilt from PostgreSQL. Redis keeps the short lived state, meaning revisit flags, cached attachment text, reminder state, and the user's capture settings. This entire storage layer runs on the user's laptop.

Three modules then work on the stored data. The enrichment worker prepares new items for search in the background, and the retrieval engine answers questions. The wellbeing module turns the stored activity into time summaries, sessions, regret

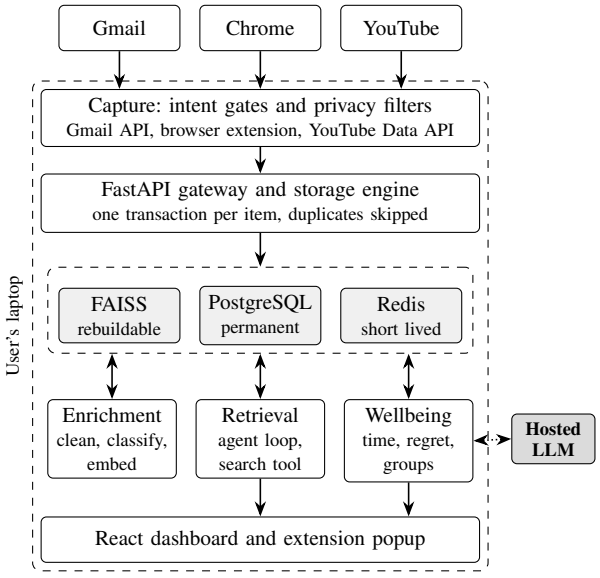


Fig. 1. Main parts of E.C.H.O. Everything inside the dashed frame runs on the user's laptop. The dotted arrow is the only path to the hosted language model of E.C.H.O; it carries bounded text from three callers (classification, retrieval, weekly reflection), described in Section VI.

patterns, and group suggestions. The main interface is a React dashboard, along with a small extension popup that lets the user pause capture.

IV. Methodology

A. Intent Aware Capture

What should E.C.H.O keep? Each source has its own answer, which is summarized in Table I. These values are the ones chosen for the final system. The browser and the server hold matching copies of them, so that the server does not silently refuse a page that the extension sends.

Gmail is treated differently from the other two sources. Mail arrives on its own and is not chosen by the user. Also, the daily volume is small, and even an unread message may matter later. So every message is stored when it arrives. The connector polls every 30 seconds, but each poll asks Gmail only for the changes since a saved history position. It does not list the entire mailbox each time. If that position has expired, the connector lists the mailbox once, and the uniqueness rule on stored items absorbs the overlap. Mail that Gmail has already filed as spam or trash is not read at all, so Gmail's own spam filter also acts as the spam filter of E.C.H.O. When the user opens a message in Gmail on the web, the extension reports the message id and the seconds spent reading, and nothing else.

A Chrome page passes a two phase gate. In phase one, the page must stay in the foreground for at least five seconds. A page that fails this phase is dropped, and only a page that passes it is remembered for revisit detection. In phase two, at least one sign of attention must appear. This sign can be enough foreground time, enough scrolling, a real interaction, or a visit to the same page within the last 24 hours. Selecting text or clicking inside the page counts as an interaction, but

TABLE I
Capture Rules for Each Source

Source	An item is kept when
Gmail	Always, at arrival, except mail in Spam or Trash. Polled every 30 s for changes only. Reading time is added when a message is opened (opens under 3 s are ignored).
Chrome	Phase 1: at least 5 s in the foreground. Phase 2: any one of at least 10 s in the foreground, at least 15% scroll depth, one interaction other than a link click, or a revisit within 24 hours. Work app pages: at least 5 s or one interaction, title only.
YouTube	Any one of at least 20 s of foreground playback (10 s for Shorts), at least 10% of the video watched with at least 5 s of watching, a pause, seek, or speed change by the user, or a revisit within 24 hours.

clicking a link does not. This is because a click that leaves the page shows a choice to go elsewhere, and not interest in the page itself. Time is counted only while the tab is active, the window has focus, and the user has not been idle for 30 seconds. Along with the text of the main content, the extension also sends the top level headings of the page. These headings later help the page to be found by its topic.

A YouTube video is kept when the user watches it long enough or watches a large enough share of it. A pause, a seek, a change of speed, or a return to the same video within a day also keeps it. The completion rule requires at least five seconds of real watching, such that swiping past a short clip does not count as watching ten percent of it. Once a video has been watched for five seconds, the extension records the visit, so that a second short visit can pass through the revisit rule. Shorts are recognized from the page address itself, and they have a lower time bar.

B. Storage Model

Each email, page, and video becomes one row in a central table of memory items. Fields that belong to a particular source go into a matching table for Gmail, Chrome, or YouTube, and attachments get a table of their own. As engagement counters such as reading time, watch time, and revisits change often, they are kept separately. Also, Chrome and YouTube write one row for every admitted visit, with the time of the visit and the seconds spent. This way, a page read on two different days is counted on both days. The complete schema has 17 tables.

A uniqueness rule on the pair of source type and source id stops the same item from being stored twice, for example after a connector restarts. Every item always carries one of the five system groups, and misc is the fallback. Items are first written in a raw state and flagged as unprocessed. This keeps the capture path short and safe against crashes. Later, if a revisited page comes back with different text, it is flagged again so that its vector is rebuilt. Timestamps are stored in UTC and shown to the user in local time.

A user can delete a single item, which hides it from every query. Apart from this, a retention setting lets the user keep items forever, for one year, or for six months. As recalling old things is the whole point of the system, keeping items

forever is the default. If the user picks a shorter window, a job at backend startup permanently removes the older items from PostgreSQL, the FAISS index, and Redis together.

C. Background Enrichment

A background worker picks up the unprocessed items every few seconds. As it runs outside the capture path, a slow enrichment step cannot slow down capture. Each item then goes through four steps.

Cleaning. For email, HTML is converted to text with the line breaks kept, and scripts, styles, tracking pixels, and hidden preview text are removed. When the sending app has split a body around an inline image, the parts are joined back together. Quoted earlier messages are removed, but the lines the sender typed between quoted lines are kept. This is because an inline reply is often the most important part of the message. A heuristic remover that we tested cut real body text in six of eight sample messages, while a leftover signature only adds a little noise. So signatures are deliberately left in place, as a little noise is better than lost body text. For a reply, keywords from earlier messages in the same thread are added, so that a terse "Re:" can still be found by its topic. For web pages, the extension has already picked the main content and the headings, and the worker separates the headings from the body. A video's text is made of its title, channel, category, tags, and description. The server also tries to download the caption text, but this is best effort, and it returned nothing for any of the 14 videos in our test data.

Attachments. The same worker extracts attachment text when the mail is processed. It supports PDF, DOCX, XLSX, PPTX, HTML, forwarded messages, and plain text formats such as TXT, CSV, Markdown, JSON, and calendar files. Images and scanned PDFs are read with Tesseract OCR [16], while inline images such as signature logos, and very small images, are skipped. The extracted text is stored next to the attachment record and not inside the email body. The beginning of each attachment joins the embedded text of the email, while the entire text joins the keyword index. So content deep inside a file can still be found by keyword.

Embedding. The cleaned text is turned into a 384 dimension vector with the `snowflake-arctic-embed-xs` sentence model [8], which reads up to 512 tokens. The text is assembled such that the short hints come first. They are the subject, keywords, and sender for mail, the domain and headings for pages, and the channel and category for videos. Long text such as a body or a description comes last. Then the text is cut to the 512 token window of the model, using the model's own tokenizer and ending at a whole word. So only the end of the long part is removed, and the stored text is exactly what was embedded. For mail with attachments, the body takes up to 300 tokens and the attachments fill the rest. For a video, the description takes up to 200 tokens and any caption text fills the rest. The vector is then added to the FAISS index without a rebuild.

Classification. Every item receives one of five broad groups, which are work, study, entertainment, personal, and misc. The group is chosen by a four stage cascade. Stage one reads structural signals from the source, such as Gmail category labels, academic mail domains, or the YouTube video category. Next, stage two looks up the web domain in a curated table. Then stage three compares the vector of the item with a center point for each group and accepts only a clear winner. Each center starts as the mean of several example sentences written for its group. While a center is still a seed, the required lead is smaller, 0.05 instead of 0.08, as we measured on labeled rows (Section VIII). Once a group has at least ten confirmed items, its center is recomputed from real items. Each source is weighted equally here, so that a center learns a topic and not the look of one particular source. Both kinds of center need a cosine similarity of at least 0.55. A recomputed center must also lead the second best group by at least 0.08. The recomputation runs when the worker starts, if the stored centers are missing or older than 30 days. Finally, stage four asks the language model, one item at a time, using only the title and about 300 characters of text. With an OpenAI model, the call is a typed choice among the five group names. With other providers, the reply must be exactly one group name, and any other reply becomes misc. If the typed call raises an error, that item takes the single word path instead, so classification does not stop. No confidence value is stored.

State tracking. Each item ends as either processed or failed. Failed items are kept apart, so a failure is not counted as done, and it is not lost either. A configuration switch lets the worker try them again.

D. Retrieval Loop

How is a question answered? It passes through the loop in Fig. 2. The language model, GPT-6 Luna, receives the conversation so far, a small calendar around today's date, the question, and one tool called `search_memories`. The tool takes a query of a few keywords. It also takes, as options, up to two alternative phrasings, a list of sources, a start date, a reference item together with the word before or after, and a flag that asks for the text of an attachment. The model decides how to phrase the search, and it may issue several searches in parallel in one round, for instance one per source. After reading the results, it either answers directly or searches again. On the first turn of a chat, the first call must use the tool. A usual question needs one call that searches and one call that answers. The code allows at most five searches for one question, and at most three in one round. After the fifth search, the next call is made without the tool, such that the model has to answer. So a question costs between two and six model calls, and this bound is enforced by the program, not by the prompt.

Resolve time phrase. The model reads the calendar in its first message and passes a start date, so a phrase such as "last Tuesday" reaches the tool as a date. The tool accepts only a valid date. A phrase that points at another item, such as "after the interview email," is passed as a reference item, and the code looks it up among the user's own items. This lookup goes first by keyword and then by meaning, with a minimum

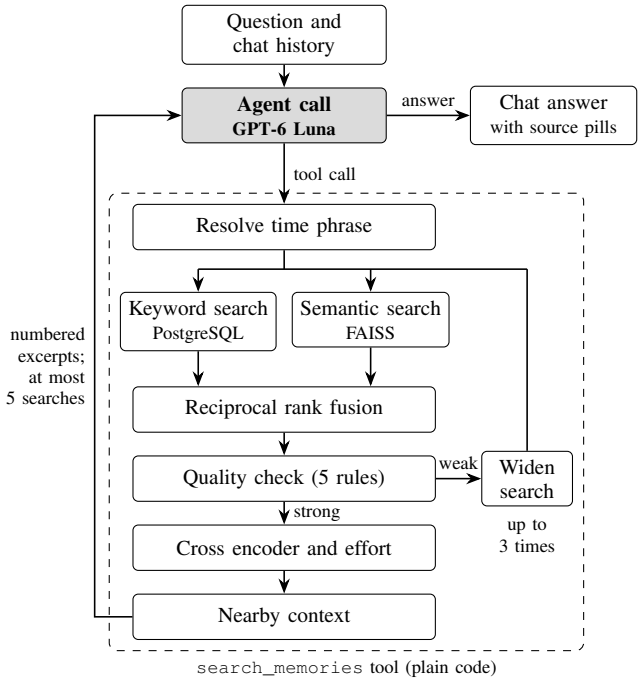


Fig. 2. The retrieval loop. The shaded box is the only place a language model is called. Everything inside the dashed frame is deterministic code with two small local encoders. When the search is widened, both search branches run again.

similarity. The time of the matching item then becomes a hard limit for both search branches. If no reference item is found, the search runs without that limit. Mail is matched by when it arrived, while pages and videos match when any of their recorded visits falls in the range. The date filter is open ended, so the answering call is told today's date and asked to use only the items inside the period the user named.

Parallel search. The keyword branch runs the PostgreSQL full text search over a stored text index. This index covers titles, the complete item text, attachment text, senders, domains, and channel names. The semantic branch embeds the query and searches FAISS. Both branches run in the same step of the graph.

Fusion. The two ranked lists are merged with reciprocal rank fusion [10]. For an item d, the fused score is

$$\mathrm{RRF}(d) = \sum_{b \in B} \frac{1}{k + r_b(d)}, \tag{1}$$

where B is the set of branches that returned d, $r_b(d)$ is its position in branch b starting from 1, and $k = 60$. Since only the positions are used, the two score scales do not have to be matched at all. The top 50 fused items move on to the next step.

Quality check and widening. Five rules judge the fused list. The list is weak or empty when it has no items or holds fewer than two items. It is also weak when no item comes from a source the user asked for, or when no item falls inside the time window. The last rule checks the best cosine similarity, and a list whose best value is below 0.55 is weak as well. On our test questions, this floor flagged none of the 38 answerable queries as weak and let 2 of 12 unanswerable queries pass (Section VIII). A weak list triggers a wider search, and both branches run again. Each attempt relaxes the search more than the one before. The first attempt stretches the time window by four days, opens all sources, or shortens the query to its core keyword. The second then drops the time filter and the anchor, and the third drops the keyword filters and searches a larger part of the vector index. After three attempts, the tool reports that nothing was found, and the model can either say so or try a different phrasing.

Reranking. The local cross encoder `ms-marco-MiniLM-L-6-v2` [11], [13] scores each remaining item against the question. It reads the title of the item followed by the beginning of its cleaned text, 512 characters in all. The final score blends this with an effort score:

$$s(d) = 0.8\,\sigma\big(c(q,d)\big) + 0.2\,e(d), \tag{2}$$

where $c(q,d)$ is the cross encoder output for question q and item d, σ is the sigmoid function, and $e(d) \in [0,1]$ is the effort score. Effort is the mean of the engagement signals that an item has, such as reading or watch time, scroll depth, revisits, interactions, and the share of a video watched. Each signal is capped and scaled to $[0,1]$. This favors the items the user gave real attention to. Email is a special case, as mail read on a phone, or never opened in the browser, has no measurable reading time. Instead of scoring such mail as zero, the reranker gives it the median effort of the other emails in the same result list. This way, an unmeasured email is neither punished nor promoted. By design, the score has no term for how recent an item is, and no diversity reranking is applied.

Nearby context and excerpts. For the top three items, the tool also adds their close neighbors. These are other emails in the same thread, or pages and videos from the same browsing session or within five minutes. Each result reaches the model as a numbered entry. This entry holds its title, source, time, the sender, site, or channel, and the beginning of its cleaned text. That excerpt is at most 8,000 characters for each of the top three results and 2,000 characters for the others. Suppose the question is about the content of a file attached to an email. Then the tool adds the extracted text of the attachment of the best ranked mail, up to 40,000 characters. The numbers stay the same across the searches of one question, so that a citation always points to the exact same item.

Writing the answer. The final call writes a conversational reply in Markdown. This reply starts with the direct answer and admits gaps plainly, and when the question is ambiguous, it asks back in one line. After each fact, the reply places a hidden marker that names the numbered item supporting it. The backend keeps only the markers that point to items the tool actually returned, so that the model cannot cite a source it did not see. The dashboard then turns each marker into a small pill. This pill names the human anchor of the memory, such as the sender, the site, or the channel, along with a short date. Clicking the pill opens the original email, page, or video. Also, a thin time strip under the reply places each cited item on a

timeline. While the loop runs, the dashboard shows progress messages, such as which source is being searched, and then it shows the reply.

Failure handling. If the model cannot be reached, the deterministic pipeline runs once on the raw question. In this case, the user still receives the ranked list of matching items, and not an error.

E. Conversation Memory

Each chat has a session id, and every turn is saved in PostgreSQL on the laptop. When the user opens an old chat, its session resumes from where it was left. So a follow up such as "show me Chrome pages about that topic after that email" can refer back to an earlier answer. At each turn, the model receives the last twelve messages of the chat, with each question cut to 1,000 characters and each answer to 3,000. The citation numbers restart with every question. Chat history older than 30 days is removed at startup.

V. Wellbeing and User Groups

The wellbeing module answers one question: where did my time go? It describes how the time is spent, but it does not judge it. So it shows the numbers and patterns, and it leaves the verdict to the user.

Time. Time totals are computed on demand from the stored records and are not stored separately. This avoids counting the same minutes twice. Page and video time come from the per visit rows, so each day receives exactly the time spent on that particular day. Email time comes from the reading time that the extension reports. All days are the local days of the user.

Sessions. A session is a run of activity in which consecutive items are less than 20 minutes apart. A shorter gap would split one sitting in two. Suppose the user reads a page for 15 minutes and then opens the next page. As each item is recorded at one point in time, that read looks like a 15 minute gap. For each session, the module records its length, the system group with the most time, and how often the user switched between sources.

Regret. It is the user who decides what is regrettable, and any item can be marked. Every mark or unmark is stored as a new event, so the record is not overwritten. An item is currently regretted when its count of events is odd. The module then reports how many marked items fall in each content type and hour. It also flags a habit when the same kind of item, at a similar hour, is marked at least three times in 30 days.

Weekly reflection. Once a week, the module can write a short reflection. For this, one language model call receives only aggregated numbers, which are totals per category, regret counts, session patterns, and peak hours. It does not receive a title, an address, or any text from an item. Before the reply is shown, it is checked for judging phrases. If it fails this check, or if the call itself fails, a simple summary built from the same numbers is shown instead.

User groups. System groups answer "what kind of item is this?", while user groups answer "which of my goals does it serve?", for example "Placement prep." A user group starts with the items that the user files by hand. Once it has five confirmed items, an assignment job scores other items against it in two ways. The first way uses the rules the user wrote, each on a keyword, domain, channel, sender, or date range. The second way is a nearest neighbor score, which is the mean cosine similarity between the item and the three most similar confirmed members. An item is suggested when a rule matches, or when the neighbor score alone reaches a threshold. We set this threshold to 0.85, the lowest value at which no item outside a group scored at or above it in our test (Section VIII). The module can also propose a new rule when at least five confirmed members share a domain, sender, or channel.

Only a confident suggestion is applied on its own. A suggestion is confident when a rule matches and the neighbor score also reaches that same threshold. Such an item is added directly, but it still appears in the weekly review, where one click undoes it. So confident items are handled with a human on the loop. Anything less certain waits for an explicit accept in the review screen, meaning that the human stays in the loop. Also, an automatic addition does not count as a confirmed member until the user keeps it. So one wrong addition cannot pull in the next similar item. Manual filing and automatic additions pass through the same recorded path, so each membership has an audit trail. A rejected or removed suggestion is not offered again for that group. User groups are independent of the five system groups and have no parent among them, such that one goal can hold study pages and work mail together.

VI. Privacy by Design

What is never captured. Nothing from incognito windows is recorded, and the same goes for typed text and form input. Some pages also keep no text at all. A page falls in this case when its address contains a sensitive word, such as login, password, checkout, otp, or netbanking. Each word is matched as a whole word against a fixed list of 38. A page with a visible password box, or with a form of several personal fields, is treated the same way. Parameters that often carry secrets, such as tokens, one time codes, and session ids, are cut from every address before it is stored. Seven work apps, which are Slack, Atlassian, Notion, Figma, Linear, Trello, and Asana, are stored only as page titles and not as text. Their public help, blog, and documentation sections are still treated as ordinary pages. Gmail on the web is skipped by browser capture, because the mail already arrives through the Gmail API. All these lists live in one copy on the server, and the extension fetches them at startup. Until they arrive, the extension extracts no text.

What leaves the laptop. The database, the vector index, the cache, and both encoders run locally. Two kinds of traffic leave the machine. First, requests to the Gmail and YouTube APIs fetch the user's own data. Second, calls to the hosted language model carry text from three callers. Retrieval sends the question, the recent chat history, and the numbered results. Each result is a title, a time, a sender, site, or channel, and the beginning of its text, at most 8,000 characters for each of the top three results and 2,000 for the others. When the

user asks about a file, the text of one attachment is added, at most 40,000 characters. The classifier sends a title and about 300 characters, and it does so only for the items that the first three stages could not place. The weekly reflection sends only aggregated numbers. So a short email can reach the model whole, but a longer email, a page, or a transcript never does beyond these limits, and database rows and vectors are never sent. Requests to the hosted service are also subject to the data retention policy of its provider. Also, when the user connects an MCP client (Section VII), the tool results go to that client, so its own language model sees the same excerpts.

Captured text is data, not instructions. A stored email or page might contain text that was written to steer a language model. The search tool is read only, and the system prompt tells the model that every excerpt is data. Together, these limit what such text can achieve. Retrieval logs record counts, scores, and timings, but not questions or titles.

User control. The user can switch off each source, exclude domains and senders, and pause capture from the extension popup. Items can also be deleted, and the user's data can be exported in full as JSON or CSV. The retention setting then removes old data for good.

VII. Implementation

Table II lists the technology used. The backend is written in Python and served by FastAPI. The retrieval loop is a LangGraph graph [5] in which an agent node and a tool node alternate under a round counter. Every model call goes through LangChain, so switching to a different provider means changing one configuration entry. When the provider is OpenAI, the code also turns on features specific to that provider. These are the Responses API, a medium reasoning effort for both retrieval calls, and the typed choice used by the classifier. The embeddings and the cross encoder run locally on the CPU through the sentence transformers library. The dashboard is built with React and TypeScript, and the extension uses Chrome Manifest V3.

PostgreSQL 16 runs as a native service on the laptop, and Redis runs locally under the Windows Subsystem for Linux. Both therefore run on the laptop, and only standard HTTPS traffic leaves the machine.

E.C.H.O also runs as a server for the Model Context Protocol (MCP) [17]. Over the stdio transport, it exposes two read only tools, `search_memories` and `get_memory`. The first one has the same contract as the tool of the retrieval loop. So any MCP client, such as Claude Desktop, can query the memory with its own language model. In that case, the client plans the searches in place of the agent loop, while E.C.H.O stays the engine that does the actual searching.

VIII. Evaluation

A. Setup

We evaluated E.C.H.O on one test account of the authors, which holds 119 items: 78 emails, 30 pages, and 11 videos. Five of the emails carry a PDF attachment whose text was extracted. The authors wrote 38 questions of five kinds: 16 about one item in one source, 4 about several sources, 6 with a time reference ("emails I received today," "after the interview email"), 6 follow up questions that refer to an earlier turn, and 6 about the content of an attachment. Before the run, the authors marked the relevant items for each question, 81 in all, with at most eight for one question. Everything ran on one Windows laptop, and the hosted model was called through its API.

TABLE II
Technology Used in the Final System

Layer	Technology
Capture	Chrome extension (Manifest V3), Gmail API, YouTube Data API
Backend	Python, FastAPI, server sent events
Storage	PostgreSQL 16, FAISS, Redis, all local
Enrichment	Text extraction for PDF, DOCX, XLSX, PPTX, and EML; Tesseract OCR
Models	`snowflake-arctic-embed-xs` embeddings (384 dimensions, 512 tokens), `ms-marco-MiniLM-L-6-v2` cross encoder, GPT-6 Luna through the OpenAI Responses API
Retrieval	LangGraph, LangChain, MCP Python SDK (stdio)
Interface	React, TypeScript, Vite

TABLE III
Retrieval Quality on 38 Questions

Configuration	R@10	R@5	MRR
Keyword only	0.697	0.697	0.693
Semantic only	0.955	0.934	0.987
Fusion, no cross encoder	0.955	0.934	0.987
Full pipeline	0.927	0.905	0.899
Full agent loop	0.927	0.905	0.899

B. Retrieval Quality

We compare five configurations. The first four replay, for each question, the arguments that the model chose in its first search, so that they differ only in the stages of the tool: keyword search alone, semantic search alone, fusion without the cross encoder, and the full pipeline with quality check, widening, and reranking. The fifth is the whole agent loop. Table III gives Recall@10, Recall@5, and the mean reciprocal rank (MRR) of the first relevant item within the first ten results. Recall@k is the number of relevant items among the first k results, divided by the smaller of k and the number of relevant items.

Keyword search alone reaches a recall of 0.70, because the full text search needs every query word to match, and for 11 of the 38 questions it found no relevant item. Semantic search alone and its fusion with keyword search both reach 0.955 with an MRR of 0.987, so on this collection the keyword branch did not change the first ten results. The full pipeline scores lower. For five questions, the right item moved from first place to second or third place after reranking. In the two questions that we examined in detail, the cross encoder gave scores below

0.01 to all candidates, so the effort term of Eq. 2 decided the order, and an email that the user had opened outranked the right one. We therefore cannot claim that reranking helps on small collections of this kind.

The top ten of the agent loop equal those of the full pipeline, because later searches add items after the first ten. The value of the loop shows over everything it showed to the model, which was 70 of the 81 relevant items against 65 for a single pass (0.86 against 0.80), at the cost of showing more results. The gain came from three questions in which a second search found items that the first one missed. By kind of question, the loop reaches a recall of 1.00 for single source, follow up, and attachment questions, 0.74 for questions over several sources, and 0.71 for questions with a time reference. In the question “after the interview email,” the model wrote the phrase into the query and did not use the reference item, which gave a recall of 0.20. The answers to all 11 questions whose answer contains a unique fact were correct.

C. Cost and Speed

The 38 questions made 44 turns, since each follow up has two. A turn needed 2.34 model calls on average: 33 turns used two calls, 8 used three, 2 used four, and 1 used five. No turn used all five searches, and the largest number of searches was four. The median response time was 8.1 seconds, the 95th percentile was 23.8 seconds, and the longest was 30.2 seconds. A turn sent 8,983 input tokens and received 238 output tokens on average. At an assumed price of 0.20 and 1.20 US dollars per million input and output tokens, this is about 0.002 dollars per turn.

D. Capture Accuracy

We replayed 15 scripted browsing and viewing sessions in a test profile of Chrome with the extension. They include a page closed after three seconds, a page read for six seconds without scrolling, a page scrolled to 20 percent, a click on a link, a text selection, a page address with a secret parameter, a video closed after three seconds, a ten minute video watched for seven seconds twice, and a video watched for 25 seconds. The expected result of each session was written down from the rules before the run. Thirteen sessions were clean, and in all 13 the stored items matched the rules (8 Chrome and 5 YouTube sessions). Two further sessions were discarded because a person used the browser during them. The sessions were driven by a script that also kept the system from going idle, and their durations are accurate to about two seconds.

E. Privacy Audit

During the evaluation, every request to the language model was recorded. The largest request held 38,469 characters. Two items in the collection are longer than the 8,000 character limit for the top results, and both were shown to the model. The text beyond the limit appeared in no request.

F. Threshold Calibration

Three similarity cutoffs depend on the embedding model, and we measured them on the collection. For the seed centers of classification stage three, the 78 emails and pages with a known group give no firing at a lead of 0.08 and 14 firings, all correct, at 0.05. No item scored below 0.585, so the score floor of 0.55 could not be tested. For the quality check, the best cosine similarity of the 38 answerable queries was at least 0.558, with a median of 0.734, while 12 queries without an answer reached at most 0.573. A floor of 0.55 flags none of the good queries and lets 2 of the 12 bad ones pass, and raising it to 0.58 would trade one query for another, so we kept 0.55. For the nearest neighbor score of user groups, we formed three groups of 13, 5, and 5 items and scored each member against the others of its group and every other item against the group. At 0.65, all 23 members pass, but so do 155 of 358 other items. At 0.85, 7 members pass and no other item does. This is the lowest value without a wrong item, and it is the one we use. The groups and their labels were written by the authors, and the sample is small.

IX. Limitations and Future Work

E.C.H.O has the following limitations. It targets desktop Chrome, so activity on the phone is not visible to it. Also, YouTube history starts on the day the extension is installed, and background or picture in picture playback is not tracked. As each item has one vector, only the first 512 tokens of a long document shape its meaning based match, and deep content can be reached only by keyword. Replies from Outlook quote the older thread without a marker that E.C.H.O removes, so such threads can appear more than once in the results. The date filter is open ended, and only the top ten results of each search reach the answering call. So on a busy day, a question about yesterday could be crowded out by the items of today. Pages of private apps outside the seven listed, such as chat assistants or online documents, are captured as ordinary pages unless the user excludes their domain. The OAuth tokens are kept as plain files on the laptop, and their only protection is the file permissions of the operating system. Captions of videos are downloaded from a public endpoint on a best effort basis, and none was returned for our videos, so the text of a video rests on its title, tags, and description. Scanned files need the Tesseract program, which was not installed in our test setup, so they were not evaluated. The evaluation covers one account with 119 items and 38 questions that the authors wrote themselves, and it does not cover the wellbeing module or the group suggestions, which were not tested with users. One question moves a recall figure by about 2.6 percentage points, and the results may not carry over to larger collections or to other users. Finally, the language model is a hosted service, so its availability and limits apply.

Future work starts with a larger evaluation on several users, with questions written by people who did not build the system. Apart from that, we plan to store several vectors for each long item, to let the domain table learn from the user’s own confirmed labels, and to revisit the reranking stage, where

the weight on engagement outweighed relevance in our test. Finally, importing past history from Google Takeout and from the browser's own history file would let a new user start with a complete memory instead of an empty one.

X. Conclusion

E.C.H.O turns email, browsing, and video history into one personal memory that can be searched in plain language. It keeps all legitimate mail, but only the pages and videos that the user paid attention to. These items are stored on the user's laptop and prepared for search in the background. Questions are answered by a loop in which a language model plans the search and deterministic code performs it. So the role of the model stays visible and bounded, and its cost stays low. Apart from retrieval, a wellbeing module describes how time is spent and keeps the user in charge of every personal grouping. On a test collection of 119 items, a question needed 2.3 model calls and a median of 8.1 seconds, and the first ten results held 93 percent of the relevant items. The tests also showed where the design falls short: the reranking stage did not improve on semantic search, and the model did not always use a reference to another item.

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